

THE MOULD
The curators of the Indian Ceramics Triennale

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

COMMON GROUND
The Indian Ceramics Triennale (indianceramicstriennale.com) is on from Jan. 19 to Mar. 31, 2024, at Arthshila, Okhla, New Delhi

most surprising, unpaid volunteers. Fundraising, they admit, none of them are good at. What they have raised is only enough to pay artists, and the eight of them (artist Sangeeta Kapila and curator Kanika Anand joined the team before this edition) pay their own expenses and rely on the goodwill of friends and supporters. All preparation has been done remotely, and the weeks before the opening were the first time all of them were in the same place since 'Breaking Ground'.

"It's fascinating," Subrahmanian says. "We are all very strong personalities, yet we manage to work together." Khanna explains, "The clay community is different, the difficulty of the material and the process..." Das Gupta continues the sentence: "...it irons out some of the kinks inside...." and Subrahmanian comes in: "...the world over, you have this connection with the material and then you make a connection with the person who has the same connection...." And Kudchadkar: "...even if we weren't friends—I mean, we're constantly bickering and then cackling—we respect each other's practices."

How will they sustain this? Will they be able to pay themselves soon? Das Gupta, Khanna, Kudchadkar and Subrahmanian—in a video call late at night after long hours at the venue setting up, settling artists in, and meetings—break into raucous laughter. They first need to cover their expenses, Das Gupta says, still laughing. "You've made the commitment willingly, so you honour your commitment." Kudchadkar concludes the thought: "You're doing it because it needs to be done and it's absolutely worth doing. But I think to make it happen, you do need the madness." ■

–Peter Griffin

Haidar, curator of Islamic Art at The Met in New York. Along with photographer Abhinav Goswami, and with the contribution of scholars Ebba Koch, George Michell and Mitchell Abdul Karim Crites, Haidar takes the reader through a visually rich journey from the *jali*'s earliest manifestations in rock-cut *chaityas* and free-standing temples like Belur, traverses its highs in Indo-Islamic tombs, mosques and palaces of Sultanate/ Mughal rulers to contemporary iterations in art. Through it, this osmosis of filtered light moves from the rudimentary to sublime 'celestial imagery'.

Haidar describes the initial appearance of the *jali* in early Islamic buildings in Gujarat, where temple-building traditions move smoothly into mosque design. Monuments like the 14th-century Hilal Khan Qazi mosque in Dholka show how far back syncretic amalgams extend, and how unself-conscious they are.

Islamic ornament eschews figural representations. In its stead, geometric, calligraphic and vegetal pattern-making rises to a high art. Through its all-encompassing articulation of surfaces, ornament dematerialises architectural bulk, and humanises the immense scales of mosques and tombs. While entrances are largely through *iwans* or grand arches, all other openings are filled with carved screens.

The *jali* is subservient to this schema when on the outside but comes into its own in interior spaces. Nowhere is this seen better than in Fatehpur Sikri, where Salim Chishti's marble tomb is wrapped around with the most intricately carved marble *jalis* to bring in kaleidoscopic light, suffusing the interiors with a 'noor-e-ilaahi', or divine light.

The dividing screens, or the *mashrabiyah*, are Middle Eastern tropes, but it is the manner of rendering and inherent symbolism that transforms them from architectural utility to devices of metaphysical contemplation. If the early Mughals incorporated divine geometries carved to mathematical perfection in stone, Shah Jahan's buildings take this to its apogee.

Most Mughal tombs, like those of Humayun or the Taj Mahal, are located in charbaghs—pavilions in walled gardens, subdivided by water channels, representing the four rivers of Islamic paradise. Shah Jahan's penchant for marble, used to its fullest in the Taj, the Khas Mahal and the Moti Masjid, breaks away from traditional geometries into an explosion of floral designs. Ebba Koch's essay explores this 'Flower Philosophy'. She reinterprets the *jali* using eclectic references and iconography, "in which the naturalistic form is eventually dissolved in floating organic arabesque and trellises." ■

–Mustansir Dalvi